

Throw-ins

Throw-ins are the most common restart in football. The technique is simple and well-defined — but small mistakes can lead to a foul throw, with possession handed straight to the other team.

Restarts and set pieces [Read the rules guide](#)

When a throw-in is given

A throw-in is awarded when the ball goes out over a touchline.

The whole of the ball must cross the touchline, on the ground or in the air, for the ball to be out of play. If only part of the ball is over the line and part is still on the line, the ball is still in play.

The throw-in is awarded to the team that did not last touch the ball. It is taken from the spot where the ball crossed the touchline.

How a throw-in is taken

The throw-in technique has a small number of strict rules.

At the moment of delivering the ball, the thrower must face the field of play, have part of each foot on the touchline or on the ground outside the touchline, and throw the ball with both hands from behind and over the head from the point where it left the field of play.

The ball is in play when it enters the field of play. If a correctly taken throw-in touches the ground before entering the field, it is retaken by the same team from the same position. If the throw-in is not taken correctly, it is awarded to the opposing team.

Opponents must stand at least 2 metres from the point on the touchline where the throw-in is taken. An opponent who unfairly distracts or impedes the thrower can be cautioned.

If a team unfairly delays taking its own throw-in, the referee can start a five-second countdown. If the throw-in is not taken by the end of the countdown, the throw-in is awarded to the opposing team. A yellow card is normally needed only if the delay becomes excessive after the throw-in has been awarded to the opposition.

Foul throws

A throw-in that breaks the technique rules is a foul throw, and possession passes to the other team.

Lifting a foot

A foot is completely off the ground at the moment the ball is delivered. A raised heel is not automatically an offence if part of the foot is still touching the ground.

Throwing one-handed

Releasing the ball with only one hand on it, even if the other hand started on the ball.

Not from behind the head

Bringing the ball out from in front of the body, or releasing it before it has come from behind and over the head.

Incorrect foot position

Placing a foot entirely inside the field of play, with no part of that foot on the touchline or on the ground outside the touchline.

What cannot happen from a throw-in

A few specific things that are allowed from other restarts are not allowed from a throw-in.

A goal cannot be scored directly from a throw-in. If the ball is thrown straight into the opponents' goal, a goal kick is awarded. If it is thrown straight into the thrower's own goal, a corner kick is awarded.

There is no offside offence if a player receives the ball directly from a throw-in. An attacker can stand beyond the last defender to receive the throw, although offside can still apply from the next touch or pass.

The thrower cannot touch the ball again until it has touched another player. If they do, an indirect free kick is usually awarded to the opposing team.

A goalkeeper cannot handle the ball inside their own penalty area directly from a throw-in taken by a teammate. If they do, an indirect free kick is awarded to the opposing team.

Long throws and set pieces

Some teams use long throw-ins as a deliberate tactic, especially in their attacking third. A long throw aimed into the penalty area can be treated like a corner, with attacking players making rehearsed runs and the defending team setting up much as they would for any other set piece. One advantage is that a player receiving the throw directly cannot be offside.

Quick throws, taken before the defending team are set, are also a common tactic. They can give the throwing team a quick attacking pass into space rather than a slow restart.